

Who Supports Transit? Individual and City-Level Predictors of Transit Policy Attitudes in Canada

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Abstract

Public transit investment is a debated question in Canadian municipal governance, yet we know little about what shapes public support for it across urban contexts. This paper examines transit and urban mobility policy attitudes among a nationally representative sample of 6,949 Canadians drawn from the 2025 Canadian Municipal Barometer, linked to a novel Transit Quality Index covering 42 census metropolitan areas. Three questions are addressed: how transit attitudes vary across Canadian cities, what individual-level factors predict them, and whether city-level transit quality shapes investment support net of individual characteristics. The results show that transit attitudes are primarily structured by individual-level factors, particularly political ideology and commute mode, while city membership explains only a small share of total variance. City-level transit quality, measured through a composite index of supply density and time competitiveness, is not significantly associated with transit investment support, hinting at a quality paradox. These findings suggest that public support for transit investment in Canada is embedded in the ideological and behavioural cleavages that structure Canadian politics more broadly, and is largely insensitive to the quality of existing transit systems.

Keywords: public transit, policy attitudes, Canadian cities, comparative study, transit quality

1 Introduction

Debates over transit investment are a fixture of municipal politics across Canada. From contested in mid-sized cities such as the Quebec City Tramway to heavily delayed projects in major urban centres like the Eglinton Crosstown LRT in Toronto, decisions about public transit involve major public resources, reshape urban form, and generate political conflict. Yet despite the stakes of these decisions, we know little about how the broader public across Canadian cities thinks about transit as a policy question, such as what drives support or opposition, how attitudes vary across urban contexts, and whether the quality of existing transit shapes how citizens evaluate new investment.

An important portion of existing research on transit attitudes focuses on the satisfaction of current users within single transit systems (Oña et al. 2016; Fellelsson and Friman 2012; Van Lierop and El-Geneidy 2016), leaving unanswered how attitudes toward transit investment vary across urban contexts and what explains that variation. Cross-city comparative analysis of transit policy support,

asking not how satisfied riders are with their system but how the broader public thinks about transit investment and urban mobility policy, remains rare in the field and essentially absent in Canada (Lightner et al. 2025; Manville and Cummins 2015). Individual-level predictors of transit policy support, including political ideology, commute behaviour, and gender, are reasonably well documented in the American context but have received little comparative attention in Canada (Briscoe et al. 2019; Lim and Moon 2022; Zhong et al. 2022). Whether city-level characteristics, and transit quality in particular, independently shape how residents think about investment remains an open empirical question.

This paper addresses these gaps using original survey data from the Canadian Municipal Barometer, a national survey platform covering citizens across Canadian municipalities, linked to a novel Transit Quality Index covering 42 Canadian census metropolitan areas. It makes three contributions. First, it documents how transit and urban mobility policy attitudes vary across Canadian cities. Second, it examines the individual-level predictors of these attitudes, including political ideology, commute mode, and gender. Third, it tests whether city-level transit quality predicts individual transit attitudes net of individual-level factors.

2 Background

2.1 Transit Policy Support

A segment of transportation research has grown towards public attitudes, driven by policy interest in modal shift and sustainable cities. However, this literature has developed largely in isolation from comparative urban research, and an important distinction has often been blurred: the difference between transit satisfaction and transit policy support.

An important portion of the literature examines satisfaction and loyalty among current transit users: how service quality perceptions shape riders' intentions to continue using transit and remain loyal to the system or to switch commuting mode from car to public transportation (Redman et al. 2013; Van Lierop and El-Geneidy 2018). These studies have generated valuable insights into what transit agencies can do to retain and gain ridership, but they address a different question than the one motivating the present study. Satisfaction among current users and modal switch intentions are not equivalent to policy support among the general population, and they may have different predictors.

Research on transit policy support, such as public willingness to fund transit investment, accept tax increases, and prioritize transit in municipal spending, is comparatively thin. Where it exists, it reveals a picture more complex than simple user self-interest. There is evidence that support for transit spending is driven primarily by belief in collective benefits, such as reduced congestion and air pollution, rather than personal use intention (Manville and Cummins 2015). Transit spending supporters are generally wealthier and less likely to use transit than riders themselves, suggesting that support for transit investment may reflect broader urban values rather than narrow self-interest. This potential disconnection of support from use has meaningful implications: it means that transit policy attitudes are possibly not only a function of transit experience but are shaped by values, ideology, and urban identity in ways that user satisfaction indicators do not capture.

Most studies in this literature focus on a single or a few cities and transit systems (Oña et al. 2016; Ojo 2019; Van Lierop and El-Geneidy 2016), making it difficult to assess how urban context shapes attitudes. Cross-city comparative analysis of transit policy support remains rare, and the field has yet to produce an account of how structural variation in transit systems relates to variation in public opinion.

2.2 Cross-City Comparative Research

Empirical cross-city comparison for understanding how context shapes transit attitudes remains limited in the literature. Existing comparative studies typically involve fewer than 10 cities (Burian et al. 2018; Felleson and Friman 2012; Ingvardson and Nielsen 2019; Murray et al. 2010; Tao et al. 2019) and cover a large variety of distinct international contexts.

Research shows that city-level context shapes mobility attitudes and behaviour in systematic ways, with infrastructure characteristics producing distinct attitudinal clusters across urban environments. Importantly, city-level differences in transit attitudes remain even after accounting for individual demographic characteristics, suggesting that something structural about the urban context independently shapes how citizens evaluate transit (Murray et al. 2010). In a larger comparative study, Klinger et al. (2013) examine 44 German cities, demonstrating that large-scale cross-city comparison is both feasible and productive for uncovering how urban context shapes mobility attitudes. However, this study remains limited to a single national context. More broadly, existing comparative work predominantly measures satisfaction among current users rather than policy support among the general population, and rarely links objective supply characteristics to subjective attitudes in an explanatory framework.

This paper addresses these gaps by examining transit and urban mobility policy attitudes across 42 Canadian CMAs among a general population sample rather than a transit user sample, by linking individual attitudes to a city-level Transit Quality Index derived from GTFS and commuting data.

2.3 Transit Attitudes in Canada

Canadian transit research has developed primarily along two streams: operational and planning studies focused on network design, ridership, and service optimization, and user-experience studies examining satisfaction and loyalty among current transit riders. The latter stream has been particularly productive, with a series of studies examining how service quality perceptions shape satisfaction and behavioural intentions in individual Canadian cities (DeWeese and El-Geneidy 2020; Grisé and El-Geneidy 2018; Habib et al. 2011; Van Lierop and El-Geneidy 2016). This body of work has brought insights into the determinants of transit loyalty and ridership retention, but it addresses a different question than the one motivating the present study: how the general public thinks about transit investment as a policy question.

Where Canadian research has moved beyond single transit systems, it has compared a number of cities on aspects that differ from attitudes toward transit policy (Negm and El-Geneidy 2024). Research that treats transit investment as an object of public opinion rather than a determinant of user behaviour remains rare in the Canadian context (Rodrigue et al. 2024). This gap in the

literature is worth looking at, given that Canadian cities exhibit important variation in transit supply, from metro networks in Montreal and Vancouver to bus-only systems in mid-sized centres, variation that would be expected to produce differences in how residents think about transit investment. To my knowledge, no study has examined transit policy attitudes across a large sample of Canadian cities simultaneously, linking individual opinion to city-level infrastructure characteristics.

2.4 Individual-Level Predictors

In the few attitudinal studies on transit investment, a number of individual-level predictors come up consistently. They are organized below around three themes: commute mode, political ideology and demographics, and social influence and urban form.

2.4.1 Commute Mode

Commute mode is among the most direct individual-level predictors of transit policy support. Transit users have direct experiential knowledge of the system and material stakes in its improvement, while car-dependent commuters may perceive transit investment as irrelevant to or in tension with their mobility needs. Transit use does predict support for transit taxes and investment (Lightner et al. 2025), likely a consequence of both experiential familiarity and material stakes.

However, the relationship between transit use and policy support is more nuanced than simple self-interest would predict. There is evidence that transit spending supporters are wealthier and less likely to use transit than riders themselves (Manville and Cummins 2015; Zhong et al. 2022), suggesting that transit support reflects broader urban values as much as personal use.

Beyond actual transit use, perceived accessibility shapes travel attitudes independently of objective service provision (Blandin et al. 2024; Mehdizadeh and Kroesen 2025). Car-dependent commuters may underestimate the quality or coverage of available transit, reinforcing negative attitudes that persist even when objective service improves. This suggests that commute mode captures not only current behaviour but an accumulated set of perceptions and habits that may be resistant to change (Adamidis et al. 2025).

2.4.2 Political ideology and Demographics

Attitudes toward transit investment are not formed in isolation from broader political predispositions. Transit investment encompasses government spending, environmental policy, and urban planning, placing it within the ideological lines that structure North American political opinion. Left-right self-placement is therefore expected to predict transit attitudes independently of experiential factors.

Transit investment has become ideologically coded in North American political culture. Research consistently shows that conservative partisanship and right-leaning ideology predict opposition to transit spending and reform, above and beyond what values, beliefs, and self-interest alone explain (Klein et al. 2022; Lightner et al. 2025; Lim and Moon 2022; Zhong et al. 2022). This pattern likely reflects the broader ideological structure of attitudes toward government spending and collective

provision: transit investment requires public expenditure, redistributes mobility access, and often involves land use regulations that constrain private development, all of which sit uneasily with preferences for limited government and market-led solutions. The ideological coding of transit is therefore not incidental but reflects a deeper alignment between transit policy and the redistributive dimensions of left-right conflict. This pattern should replicate in the Canadian context, where left-right ideology and party identification structure policy attitudes across domains, though the strength of the partisan divide may differ given the distinct configuration of Canadian party politics.

Gender is another predictor of transit attitudes, though the relationship is more nuanced than a simple gap in transit use. Research shows that women complete a disproportionate share of care-related travel, including trips to escort children, run household errands, and fulfill other domestic responsibilities, and that this travel tends to involve complex trip-chaining patterns that are particularly sensitive to the quality and accessibility of the overall transportation system (Fan 2017; Ravensbergen et al. 2023). Women also exhibit greater sensitivity to the variables that shape modal choice, suggesting that transportation system characteristics weigh more heavily in their travel decisions than in those of men (Sánchez and González 2016). Beyond mobility practices, evidence shows that women tend to express stronger environmental concern than men across multiple domains, and pro-transit attitudes are partly rooted in environmental values rather than purely instrumental considerations (Alfaro et al. 2025; Briscoe et al. 2019; Kawgan-Kagan 2020). These patterns do not linearly predict that women use transit more than men, particularly given that care travel in North American contexts is frequently completed by car. They do, however, suggest that women have stronger and more complex stakes in transportation policy, which might mean that women express greater support for transit investment than men on average.

2.4.3 Social influence and Urban Form

Beyond individual sociodemographic characteristics, the context in which residents live shapes transit attitudes through several interrelated pathways. At the most immediate level, social influence affects transit orientations: exposure to others' transit experiences through social networks, peer behaviour, and word of mouth affects willingness to use and support public transit (Hurst et al. 2024; Lei et al. 2025). Research suggests that indirect contact with transit through social norms can be a stronger predictor of transit attitudes than direct service contact, suggesting that the social meaning of transit use shapes attitudes beyond individual experience (Murray et al. 2010).

Residential context operates through a related but distinct mechanism. Research shows that the urban-suburban divide is a strong predictor of transit support in Canadian cities, with residents of denser, transit-rich urban cores expressing different orientations toward transit investment than those in automobile-dependent suburbs (Walks 2015). This divide reflects more than differential access to transit. Residents of automobile-dependent suburbs are often tied to the system of automobility through housing location, vehicle ownership, and daily mobility routines, making transit investment feel either irrelevant or threatening to their way of life. Residential context therefore shapes transit attitudes through material stakes, not just service exposure.

The built environment mediates part of this relationship. Residential density, land use mix, and proximity to transit infrastructure shape travel behaviour and, through repeated experience, transit familiarity and attitudes (Liu et al. 2024; Tao et al. 2024). Since cities with better transit also tend

to be denser, city-level transit quality and individual residential context are partially confounded in cross-city analysis. Including commute mode as an individual-level control partially addresses this by capturing the behavioural dimension of residential context.

At the city level, objective transit quality itself may shape population-level attitudes through two competing mechanisms. Under a satisfaction hypothesis, residents of cities with better transit have more positive direct or indirect experience with the system, producing stronger support for transit investment. Under a dissatisfaction hypothesis, residents of cities with poor transit are more aware that their transit system is inadequate, producing stronger demand for improvement. On this account, dissatisfaction with current service drives investment support rather than satisfaction with it. Research on the relationship between transit supply and attitudes offers relevant but inconclusive evidence on this question: studies find that structural features of transit systems do not directly translate into citizen satisfaction, a pattern sometimes described as the quality paradox, suggesting that the link between objective quality and attitudinal outcomes is mediated by expectations, habits, and social context (Friman and Felleson 2009; Ingvardson and Nielsen 2019). Whether the same paradox holds for policy support rather than satisfaction is an open empirical question that this paper tries to address. It is plausible that the quality paradox holds for satisfaction but not for investment support: citizens in cities with poor transit may be dissatisfied but consequently more supportive of investment, while citizens in cities with good transit may be satisfied but take it for granted and express less urgency about further improvement.

3 Research Questions and Hypotheses

The literature reviewed above motivates three research questions. The first is descriptive and exploratory, reflecting the absence of prior comparative work on the structure and distribution of transit policy attitudes in Canadian cities. Given this absence, no predictions are made. These questions are treated as a necessary empirical foundation for the analysis that follows.

RQ1: *How do transit and urban mobility policy attitudes vary across Canadian cities?*

RQ2: *What individual-level factors are associated with urban mobility policy attitudes in Canadian cities?*

Based on the literature reviewed above, three individual-level predictors generate directional hypotheses.

H2a: All else being equal, more right-leaning Canadians express less support for transit policies and investment, on average.

H2b: All else being equal, Canadians commuting by public transit or active transport express greater support for transit policies and investment, on average.

H2c: All else being equal, women express greater support for transit policies and investment than men, on average.

The third research question concerns whether city-level transit quality is associated with individual transit policy attitudes.

RQ3: *Is city-level transit quality associated with individual transit policy attitudes?*

Two competing mechanisms generate opposite predictions. Under a satisfaction hypothesis, residents of cities with better transit have more positive direct and indirect experiences with the system, generating stronger support for transit investment. Under a dissatisfaction hypothesis, residents of cities with poor transit are more aware of its inadequacy, generating stronger demand for improvement (Friman and Felleson 2009; Ingvardson and Nielsen 2019). Both competing hypotheses are presented.

H3a: Canadians living in cities with better transit quality tend to express greater support for transit policies, on average.

H3b: Canadians living in cities with worse transit quality tend to express greater support for transit policies, on average.

4 Data and Methods

4.1 Survey data

Survey data come from the Canadian Municipal Barometer (CMB), a national research initiative covering citizens and elected officials across Canadian municipalities¹. The general population survey was conducted in January and February 2025 using an online panel, and resulting in a nationally representative sample of 6,949 Canadian adults. Respondents are linked to their census metropolitan area (CMA) via postal code, making it possible to match individual-level responses to city-level characteristics.

The survey includes a broad battery of urban policy attitude items, most measured on four-point Likert scales, rescaled from 0 to 1 for analysis. The survey employs a split-sample design in which attitude items were administered to randomly assigned subsamples, reducing respondent burden but limiting the number of items any single respondent answered. As a result, effective sample sizes vary across items, from approximately 600 respondents for some general policy items to over 6,000 for items administered to the full sample.

4.2 Dependent variables

The primary dependent variable of this paper is support for municipal transit investment: “My municipality should invest more in public transit infrastructure in my neighbourhood, even if it means a slight increase in taxes” (n = 4,183 after further manipulation).

Secondary outcomes include support for active transportation infrastructure (“Municipalities should make their roads accessible to active transportation, even if it means sacrificing driving lanes and/or parking”, n = 6,479) and support for increased housing density (“Municipalities should encourage increased housing density in established neighbourhoods, even if some local residents object”, n = 6,226). These items were administered to larger subsamples and are used in

¹<https://www.cmb-bmc.ca/research/>

supplementary analyses examining whether city-level transit quality is associated with a broader range of urban mobility attitudes.

Transit investment allocation preferences are measured through three items asking respondents where transit investment should be directed: urban versus suburban areas, high versus low ridership corridors, and high versus low income neighbourhoods. Each is measured on a five-point scale rescaled from 0 to 1, where 0 indicates a preference for urban, high-ridership, or high-income areas and 1 indicates a preference for suburban, low-ridership, or low-income areas ($n \approx 4,200$ each).

The analytical sample is further restricted to respondents residing in one of the 42 CMAs for which a Transit Quality Index score is available (see below), resulting in a final analytic sample of 4,016 respondents across 42 CMAs.

4.3 Independent variables

Political ideology is measured using a self-placement scale from 0 (left) to 10 (right), rescaled from 0 to 1 for analysis. Party identification is measured as self-reported federal party affiliation, with respondents identifying with the Liberal Party (LPC), Conservative Party (CPC), New Democratic Party (NDP), Bloc Québécois (BQ), Green Party (GPC), or as independent.

Commute mode is measured by asking respondents how they usually commute to work, with responses categorized as driving, public transit, active transport (walking or cycling), or other. Gender is operationalized as a binary indicator where 1 = woman and 0 = all other responses.

Models also include demographic controls for age (five categories), education (below high school, high school, university degree or above), household income (under \$50,000, \$50,000–\$174,999 and \$175,000 and above), and residential context (urban, suburban, or rural).

4.4 Transit Quality Index

To operationalize city-level transit quality, a Transit Quality Index (TQI) for the 42 Canadian CMAs with populations exceeding 100,000 is constructed. The 100,000 threshold is a subjective point below which scheduled fixed-route transit service becomes minimal and inconsistent across systems, making cross-city comparison unreliable. The index is made of two dimensions: a Supply Index and a Time Competitiveness Index. They are combined via geometric mean, so that a city must perform reasonably well on both dimensions to score highly. Imbalance is therefore penalized: A system that offers abundant supply but fails to compete with the car in travel time, or that achieves competitive travel times on a sparse network, will receive a lower score than one that performs well across both dimensions.

The supply dimension captures the density and frequency of transit service within a CMA. Route coverage is measured as route-kilometres per km² of CMA area, derived from the Canadian Public Transit Network Database (StatsCan 2025), which provides GTFS feed data for transit agencies across Canada. Area normalization is preferred over per-capita normalization because per-capita measures conflate service quality with population density. A sparse suburban network serving few people can appear well-served on a per-capita basis. Route-kilometres per km² instead captures how

thoroughly transit infrastructure covers urban space, which is more directly relevant to residents' access to the system.

Service frequency is derived from GTFS headway data, which is the average time between consecutive vehicle arrivals on a route, and is extracted from either the frequencies.txt file where available, or computed from stop departure times as a fallback. Route coverage and frequency are combined into a service-kilometre measure (Friman and Felleson 2009), for each mode m :

$$S_m = \frac{RouteKm_m}{Area} \times \frac{1440}{h_m}$$

where $RouteKm_m$ is total route kilometres for mode m , $Area$ is CMA area in km^2 , 1440 is the number of minutes in a day, and h_m is the average headway in minutes for mode m . This measure rewards both spatial coverage and temporal regularity. Modal weights are applied to reflect the documented preference for rail-based transit over equivalent bus services and rail's disproportionate role in structuring urban mobility patterns and identity (Ferbrache and Knowles 2017; Lin et al. 2022; Lorenzo Varela et al. 2018; Scherer and Dziekan 2012). Bus routes receive a weight of 1, bus rapid transit 1.5, commuter rail 2, light rail 3, and subway 5. The raw supply score aggregates across modes as:

$$Supply = \sum_m w_m \cdot S_m$$

where w_m is the modal weight for mode m . The supply score is then normalized on a 0 to 1 scale using percentile rank within the 100,000+ CMA sample. Sensitivity analyses examining alternative modal weights are provided in table 4 of the Appendix.

The competitiveness dimension captures how well transit competes with the private car as a commuting option (Fu and Xin 2007; Redman et al. 2013). For each CMA, the ratio of average transit to car commute times is computed across five distance bands: 1–3, 3–5, 5–7, 7–10, and 10–15 kilometres using average commute time data from the 2021 Census of Population (StatsCan 2022a, 2022b). Distance bands above 15 kilometres are excluded on the assumption that transit is rarely a competitive option for longer urban commutes. Ratios are weighted by the number of transit commuters in each distance band, so that distance ranges where more people actually use transit contribute more to the city's score:

$$\tau = \frac{\sum_b \left(\frac{t_b^{transit}}{t_b^{car}} \right) \cdot n_b}{\sum_b n_b}$$

where b indexes distance bands, $t_b^{transit}$ and t_b^{car} are average transit and car commute times in band b , and n_b is the number of transit commuters in band b . The ratio is then scaled from 0 to 1, where 1 indicates perfect competitiveness (equal transit and car times) and 0 indicates very poor competitiveness:

$$C = \max\left(1 - \frac{\tau - 1}{3}, 0\right)$$

The index decreases linearly as the transit-to-car time ratio increases, and is floored at 0 to prevent negative values.

The Supply Index and Time Competitiveness Index are combined via geometric mean, resulting in the final Transit Quality Index:

$$TQI = \sqrt{Supply \times C}$$

Population data for 2025 are drawn from Statistics Canada’s post-censal population estimates (StatsCan 2026), and CSD boundary files are from the 2021 Census geographic files (and later matched to CMAs).

The index behaves as expected, with Canada’s largest cities occupying the top three positions. Across the 42 CMAs, TQI scores range from 0.04 to 0.80 with a mean of 0.48 and a standard deviation of 0.20 (see table 3 in the Appendix for full results). Victoria’s fourth-place ranking is notable considering its population, and reflects strong performance on both dimensions: a dense bus network and competitive travel times relative to the car. Hamilton and Quebec City also rank highly, the former driven by good supply density, the latter by competitive travel times.

At the lower end, Chatham-Kent and Saguenay score near zero on the supply index, a result of very few structured fixed-route transit networks. Several mid-sized cities show an interesting divergence between dimensions: Chilliwack, Kelowna, Kamloops, and Saint John score relatively well on competitiveness, suggesting that where transit exists, it is reasonably competitive with the car, but very poorly on supply, indicating that the network is too sparse to provide meaningful system-wide coverage. This is why combining both dimensions into a composite index is preferable to relying on either alone.

4.5 Analytical strategy

The analysis proceeds in three steps corresponding to the three research questions. For RQ1, city-level means are computed for each attitude item and compared across CMAs. A one-way ANOVA is used to assess whether variation in transit attitudes across cities is statistically significant, with eta-squared (η^2) reported as a measure of the proportion of variance explained by city membership.

For RQ2 and RQ3, ordinary least squares regression models are estimated with transit investment support as the dependent variable. Four nested models are fitted. The first is a baseline model including the theoretically motivated individual-level predictors. The second adds demographic controls and province fixed effects, which absorb provincial-level variation in political culture and transit funding and allow individual-level predictors to be estimated net of this contextual variation. The third model adds the Transit Quality Index as a city-level predictor, allowing for the estimation of the association between overall transit quality and individual attitudes net of individual-level factors. The fourth model replaces the composite TQI with its two constituent sub-indices separately, allowing for an examination of whether the supply dimension and the time competitiveness dimension of transit quality have distinct associations with attitudes, or whether the effect is driven primarily by one component.

Because respondents within the same city share a common context, standard errors are clustered at the CMA level. CR2 standard errors are used, being more reliable when having under 50 clusters. The intraclass correlation coefficient for the primary outcome is low ($ICC = 0.027$), indicating that respondents within the same city are only marginally more similar to each other than respondents across cities. As a result, the effect of clustering is modest: a comparison of clustered and unclustered standard errors confirms that results are unchanged regardless of this choice, as reported in the supplementary appendix (table 6).

5 Results

Figure 1 presents mean support across all urban mobility attitude items among Canadian respondents². A few patterns are worth noting. Support for transit investment is moderate overall, with respondents expressing stronger support when the question is framed at the level of government generally (mean = 0.61) than when asked specifically about their own municipality (mean = 0.52). This gap is consistent with a pattern in public opinion research by which support for government spending is higher when the question is abstract and distant than when it involves local taxes and immediate trade-offs (Manville and Cummins 2015).

Among active mobility items, support for accommodating active transportation even at the cost of driving lanes is moderate (mean = 0.57), while support for expanding bike lanes at the expense of car lanes is the lowest of all items (mean = 0.43) and the only item where the average response is not in favor. This is indicative of how Canadians are broadly supportive of sustainable mobility in principle, but more resistant to concrete reallocation of road space away from cars, especially for bikes.

On issue salience, roads and highways are rated as more important municipal priorities than public transit (0.70 vs. 0.66). This seems to reflect the car-dependent reality of most Canadian cities. Climate change policy ranks lowest among the three salience items (mean = 0.56).

Regarding transit investment priorities, Canadians lean slightly toward directing investment toward urban rather than suburban areas and toward high-ridership rather than low-ridership corridors. However, they express a clear preference for directing investment toward lower-income areas.

Table 1: Variation in Urban Mobility Policy Attitudes Across Canadian Cities

Outcome	F	df ₁	df ₂	p	η^2
Transit investment	3.11	41	4141	<.001	0.030
Active transportation	2.16	41	4959	<.001	0.018
Housing density	2.32	41	4759	<.001	0.020

Note: One-way ANOVA, 42 Canadian CMAs. η^2 = proportion of variance explained by city.

Transit and urban mobility policy attitudes vary significantly across Canadian cities, as indicated by the one-way ANOVA across the 42 CMAs in table 1. City membership explains a small but

²These results are also presented in table 5 of the Appendix

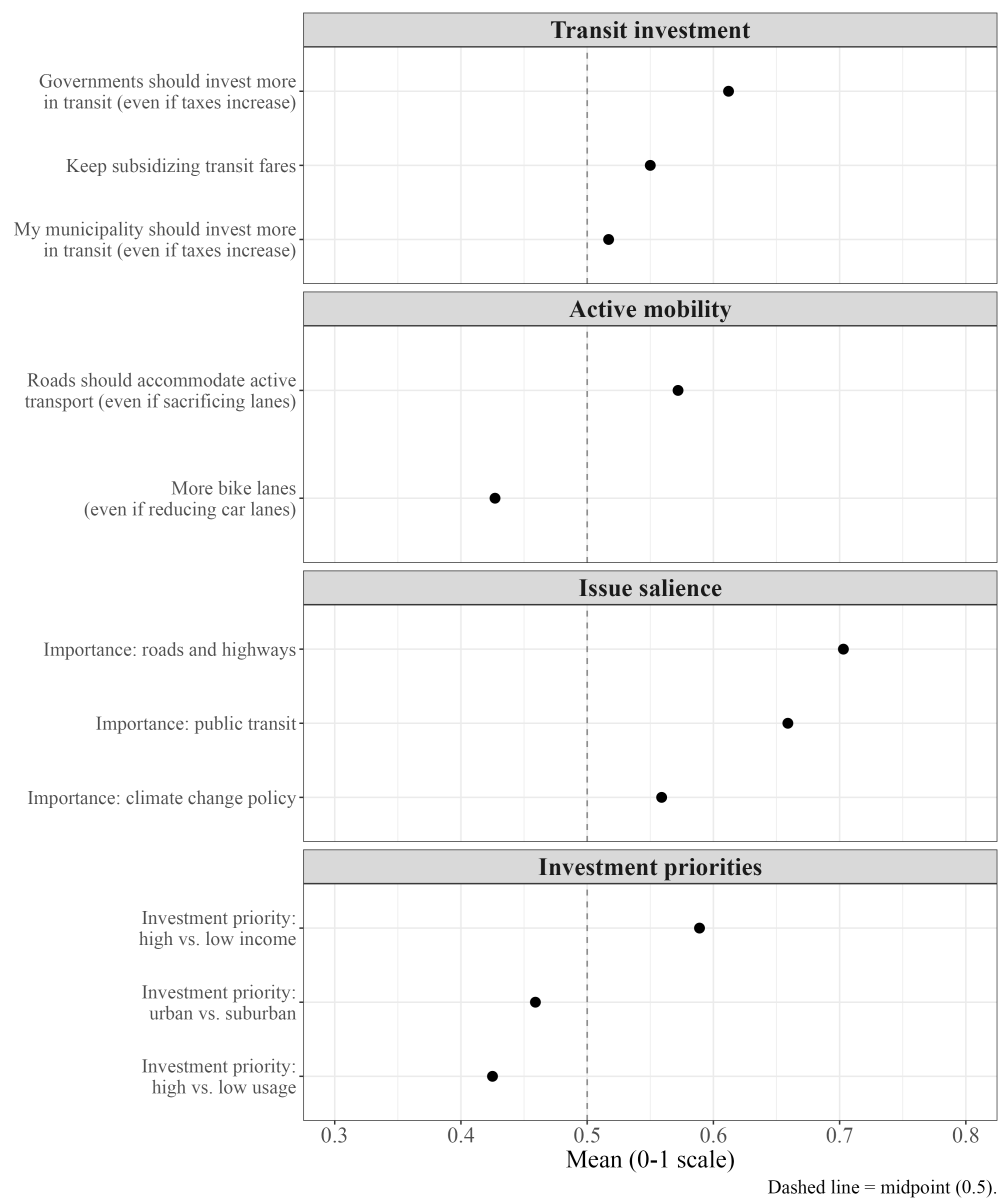


Figure 1: Urban Mobility Attitudes

statistically significant share of variance in transit investment support ($p < .001$, $\eta^2 = 0.03$), active transportation support ($p < .001$, $\eta^2 = 0.02$), and housing density support ($p < .001$, $\eta^2 = 0.02$). The fact that city membership explains only 2–3% of total variance is itself a substantive finding. It suggests that individual-level characteristics, rather than urban context, are the primary drivers of transit policy attitudes, a question taken up in the following sections.

Figure 2 displays city-level mean support for municipal transit investment among CMAs with at least 50 respondents. The range of support spans roughly 20 percentage points, from Windsor and Vancouver at the high end to Quebec City and Edmonton at the low end, indicating meaningful but not dramatic variation across cities. Notably, the city-level pattern does not map onto transit quality. Some cities with good transit systems, such as Hamilton and Quebec City, rank among the less supportive, while cities with more modest transit networks, like Windsor and Halifax, express relatively strong support. Conversely, Vancouver, which scores highest on the TQI, also ranks among the most supportive cities. This mixed picture is consistent with the competing theoretical mechanisms outlined above and motivates the formal test of the TQI-attitudes relationship below.

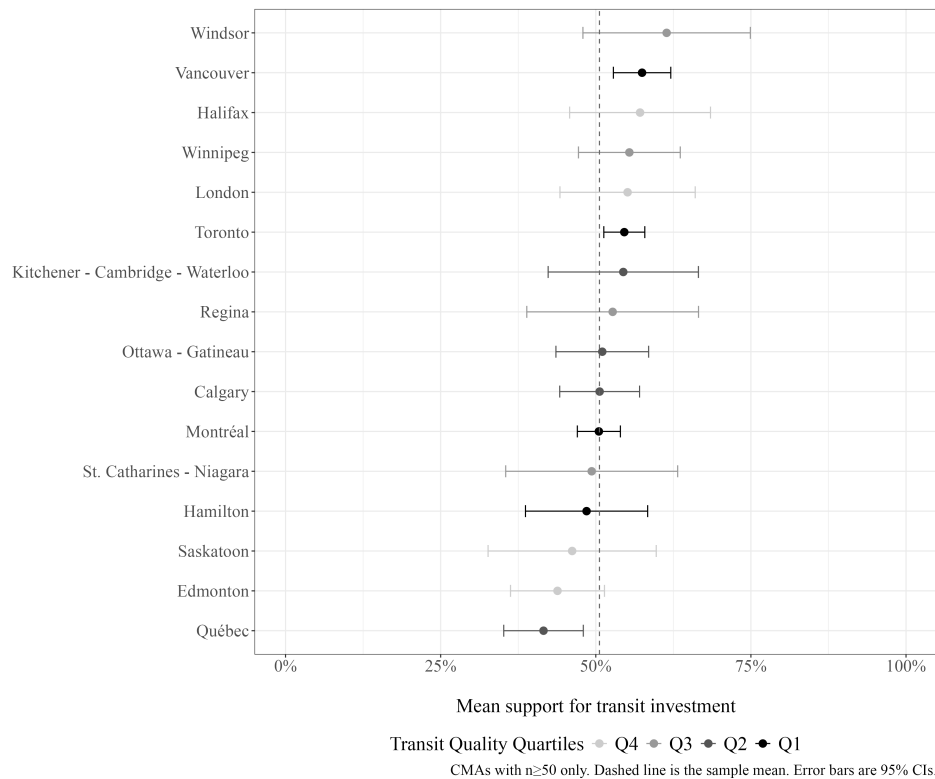


Figure 2: Municipal Transit Investment Support

Table 2 presents OLS regression models predicting support for municipal transit investment. Model 1 includes the theoretically motivated predictors and Model 2 adds demographic controls and province fixed effects. Individual-level factors explain approximately 10% of variance in transit investment support (Adj. $R^2 = 0.09$ in M2), consistent with the ANOVA finding that most variation in transit attitudes occurs within rather than between cities.

The results support H2a. In Model 2, left-right ideology is negatively and significantly associated

with transit investment support ($\beta = -0.102$, $\rho = .028$), indicating that more right-leaning Canadians express less support for transit investment on average. The effect is stable across model specifications, though it reaches conventional significance thresholds only in Model 2 after controls are added.

H2b is also supported. Relative to car commuters, both public transit users ($\beta = 0.103$, $\rho = .006$) and active transport users ($\beta = 0.083$, $\rho = .005$) express greater support on average for transit investment in Model 2. The effect is larger for transit users than active transport users, consistent with the idea that those who use transit daily have the most direct stake in its improvement.

The results do not support H2c as stated. Women express significantly less support for transit investment than men in both models ($\beta = -0.030$, $\rho = .040$ in M2), contrary to the predicted direction. This finding is robust across model specifications, though the coefficient is stable and small in magnitude. One possible explanation is that women's greater involvement in care-related travel generates stronger material stakes in automobile infrastructure than in transit investment.

Models 3 and 4 add city-level transit quality to the individual-level predictors estimated in Model 2. The individual-level findings reported above remain stable across all specifications, confirming their robustness to the inclusion of city-level measures.

Regarding RQ3, neither hypothesis is supported. The Transit Quality Index is not significantly associated with transit investment support in Model 3 ($\beta = 0.098$, $\rho = .195$), and decomposing the index into its constituent dimensions in Model 4 leads to similarly null results. Adding city-level transit quality does not meaningfully improve model fit, with adjusted R^2 increasing by less than one percentage point relative to Model 2. This null result is consistent with Friman and Fellelsson (2009) quality paradox: transit quality does not necessarily translate into policy attitudes.

To investigate whether the null result generalizes across attitude dimensions, additional models are estimated with the TQI as the key predictor across five alternative outcomes: active transportation support, housing density support, and three transit investment allocation preferences. Figure 3 presents the TQI coefficient and confidence interval for each outcome. The TQI is not significantly associated with active transportation support ($\beta = -0.001$, $\rho = .985$), housing density support ($\beta = -0.094$, $\rho = .073$), investment priorities by usage level ($\beta = 0.004$, $\rho = .933$), or income targeting ($\beta = -0.036$, $\rho = .443$). The one exception is investment allocation by geographic area: Canadians living in cities with better transit quality lean more strongly toward directing transit investment toward urban rather than suburban areas, which suggest people prefer investing in already transit-rich areas³.

6 Discussion

Three sets of findings emerge from the analysis, each with implications for how we understand the formation of transit policy attitudes and the relationship between urban infrastructure and public opinion.

The most consistent finding across all analyses is that individual-level characteristics are stronger predictors of transit investment support than the urban context in which respondents live. City

³See table 7 in the Appendix.

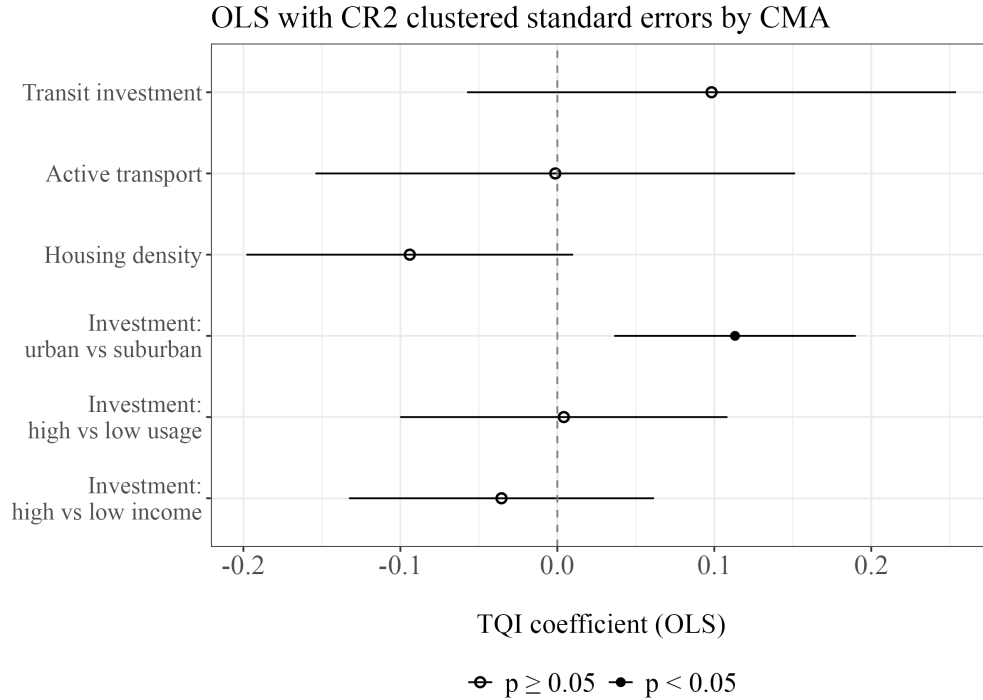
Table 2: Individual and city-level predictors of transit investment support

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4
Left-right ideology	−0.08 (0.04)	−0.10* (0.04)	−0.10* (0.04)	−0.10* (0.04)
Woman	−0.03* (0.01)	−0.03* (0.01)	−0.03* (0.01)	−0.03* (0.01)
Low income	0.00 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)	0.01 (0.02)
High income	−0.01 (0.04)	−0.01 (0.03)	−0.01 (0.03)	−0.01 (0.03)
Public transit	0.13** (0.02)	0.10** (0.02)	0.10** (0.02)	0.10** (0.02)
Active transport	0.10** (0.02)	0.08** (0.02)	0.08** (0.02)	0.08** (0.02)
BQ	−0.07 (0.03)	−0.00 (0.06)	−0.00 (0.06)	−0.00 (0.06)
CPC	−0.05 (0.03)	−0.03 (0.02)	−0.03 (0.02)	−0.03 (0.02)
Green	−0.01 (0.04)	−0.02 (0.04)	−0.01 (0.04)	−0.01 (0.04)
NDP	0.06* (0.02)	0.05* (0.02)	0.05* (0.02)	0.05* (0.02)
Transit Quality Index			0.10 (0.07)	
Supply index				0.08 (0.06)
Competitiveness index				−0.07 (0.16)
Province FE	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Controls	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
R ²	0.07	0.10	0.11	0.11
Adj. R ²	0.07	0.09	0.09	0.09
nobs	1762	1762	1762	1762

OLS with CR2 clustered standard errors by CMA.

Reference categories: Driving, LPC, Low income. Controls: age, education, urban/suburban residence.

*** $p < 0.001$; ** $p < 0.01$; * $p < 0.05$.



All models include individual-level controls and province fixed effects.

Figure 3: TQI Effect Size on Alternative Dependent Variables

membership explains only 2–3% of variance in transit attitudes, and the intraclass correlation coefficient ($ICC = 0.027$) indicates that residents of the same city are barely more similar to each other in their transit attitudes than residents of different cities. Even when city-level transit quality is directly measured and included as a predictor, it adds virtually nothing to the explained variance in transit investment support. Taken together, these findings suggest that Canadian cities, despite having different transit systems, do not produce meaningfully different transit attitude variation among their residents. Transit attitudes appear to be structured primarily by individual political and behavioural characteristics that cut across urban contexts.

This finding is consequential regarding the level at which context operates. Province fixed effects absorb meaningful variation in transit attitudes beyond what individual characteristics explain, suggesting that if geographic context matters at all, it does so at the provincial rather than the municipal level. This can perhaps be explained by the fact that transit funding in Canada is largely a provincial responsibility. Alternatively, it could simply mean that provincial political cultures shape the broader policy environment within which municipal transit debates take place. Future research might examine provincial-level attitude variation more directly.

Friman and Felleson (2009) documented a quality paradox in the transit satisfaction literature: objective transit quality does not predict how satisfied riders are with their system. The present findings extend this paradox to policy support. Across 42 Canadian CMAs with important variation in transit quality, neither the composite Transit Quality Index nor its constituent supply and competitiveness dimensions predict support for municipal transit investment among the general population. This null result is robust to alternative model specifications and holds across a range

of secondary attitude outcomes including active transportation support and housing density preferences.

If improving transit quality does not generate stronger public support for further investment, the feedback loop between service provision and political demand that many transit advocates implicitly assume may not operate as expected. Residents of cities with higher-end transit like Vancouver, Montréal and Toronto are not meaningfully more supportive of transit investment than residents of cities with sparse networks. This challenges a common justification for transit investment: that building ridership and improving quality will generate the political momentum needed for continued expansion. It is possible that transit attitudes are formed through political, experiential and cultural lenses that are largely independent of what the system offers.

The individual-level findings paint a consistent picture: transit investment support in Canada is ideologically coded and experientially grounded. More right-leaning Canadians express less support for transit investment net of other factors, replicating the partisan transit divide documented in the United States (Klein et al. 2022; Lim and Moon 2022) in the Canadian context. This finding suggests that transit investment has become embedded in the left-right ideological conflict that structures Canadian federal politics, with implications for how transit advocacy and policy communication should be targeted.

Commute mode is among the strongest predictors, with public transit and active transport users expressing greater support than car commuters. This is consistent with the findings that those with direct contact with transit have more favourable attitudes toward it (Lightner et al. 2025) rather than pure material self-interest, since transit supporters in the aggregate tend to be wealthier non-riders (Manville and Cummins 2015). Notably, the effect is larger for transit users than active transport users, suggesting that direct daily experience with the transit system, rather than a general sustainable mobility orientation, is the more powerful driver of investment support.

Contrary to the hypothesis that women would express greater support for transit and active transportation policies, consistent with evidence of stronger pro-environmental and pro-sustainable-mobility orientations among women (Alfaro et al. 2025; Briscoe et al. 2019; Kawgan-Kagan 2020), women in this sample express significantly less support for municipal transit investment than men. This result is robust across model specifications. One possible explanation is that women's greater involvement in care-related travel, which in North American contexts is by a wide majority completed by car rather than transit, generates stronger material stakes in automobile infrastructure than in transit investment (Fan 2017; Ravensbergen et al. 2023). It is also possible that the gender gap in transit attitudes does not generalize to the Canadian context, where patterns of car dependence and suburban residential form may interact differently.

Several limitations should be noted. The observational design does not allow for causal conclusions. The split-sample survey design, while reducing respondent burden, limits the number of attitude items available for any given respondent and prevented a joint factor analysis of the attitude battery. Finally, the Transit Quality Index captures only a portion of what constitutes transit quality. Beyond additional variables that could strengthen the index, city-level measurement hides intra-urban heterogeneity. Residents of the same city may have vastly different transit experiences depending on their neighbourhood. An analysis conducted at the neighbourhood level would allow for a more precise test of the relationship between experienced transit quality and attitudes, and represents a potential avenue for future research.

7 Conclusion

This paper set out to examine how transit and urban mobility policy attitudes are distributed across Canadian cities, what individual-level factors predict them, and whether city-level transit quality shapes how residents think about investment.

Transit attitudes in Canada are primarily structured by who people are, not where they live. Political ideology and commute mode are the dominant predictors of transit investment support, while city membership explains only a small share of total variance. Residents of cities with great transit systems are not meaningfully more supportive of further investment than residents of cities with sparse networks. This finding extends the quality paradox of transit satisfaction to the domain of policy support: objective transit quality, measured through a composite index of supply and time competitiveness, does not translate into stronger public demand for transit investment.

This has an implication for how transit advocates and policymakers think about building political support for transit expansion. A common intuition holds that improving transit service generates ridership, which in turn generates political constituency for further investment, creating a virtuous cycle of expansion. The findings here cast doubt on at least part of this logic. If the general public's support for transit investment is largely insensitive to the quality of the existing system, then improving service may not, on its own, move the needle on public opinion. Instead, transit investment support appears to be embedded in the broader ideological and behavioural cleavages that structure Canadian politics: right-leaning citizens oppose it and car-dependent commuters are less supportive, regardless of what their city's transit system offers.

This does not mean that transit investment is futile or that quality is irrelevant. Commute mode is itself one of the strongest predictors of transit support, and expanding access and ridership may shift the individual-level distribution of attitudes over time even if it does not immediately shift aggregate opinion. The pathway from quality to support may be longer and more indirect than assumed, running through behavioural change rather than attitudinal change directly.

Future research should examine transit attitudes at different geographic scales. The provincial level needs attention, given the central role of provinces in transit funding, while neighbourhood-level analysis would allow for a more precise test of how proximate transit experience shapes attitudes.

Canadian cities are investing heavily in transit infrastructure. Understanding who supports these investments, why, and whether improving systems builds broader public backing is important. This paper offers a first systematic look at that question at national scale, and the answers it provides suggest that the politics of transit in Canada are more ideologically structured and less responsive to urban context.

8 Appendix

8.1 Transit Quality Index Supplementary Material

Table 3: Transit Quality Index scores for all 42 Canadian CMAs

Rank	CMA	TQI	Supply index	Competitiveness index
1	Vancouver	0.798	0.951	0.670
2	Montréal	0.784	1.000	0.615
3	Toronto	0.748	0.927	0.603
4	Victoria	0.719	0.780	0.663
5	Hamilton	0.711	0.976	0.518
6	Québec	0.701	0.805	0.610
7	Calgary	0.682	0.829	0.561
8	Guelph	0.647	0.902	0.464
9	Oshawa	0.644	0.854	0.486
10	Ottawa - Gatineau	0.634	0.732	0.549
11	Kitchener - Cambridge - Waterloo	0.612	0.878	0.426
12	Kingston	0.605	0.610	0.601
13	Abbotsford - Mission	0.601	0.707	0.511
14	Red Deer	0.596	0.659	0.539
15	Nanaimo	0.593	0.585	0.600
16	Regina	0.563	0.561	0.566
17	Windsor	0.559	0.634	0.493
18	St. Catharines - Niagara	0.557	0.756	0.410
19	Sherbrooke	0.552	0.537	0.567
20	Winnipeg	0.549	0.463	0.651
21	Barrie	0.534	0.683	0.418
22	Edmonton	0.520	0.512	0.527
23	London	0.465	0.439	0.493
24	Halifax	0.451	0.390	0.520
25	Peterborough	0.447	0.415	0.481
26	Drummondville	0.435	0.366	0.518
27	St. John's	0.427	0.488	0.373
28	Chilliwack	0.399	0.220	0.724
29	Moncton	0.393	0.341	0.453
30	Saskatoon	0.392	0.317	0.484
31	Kelowna	0.350	0.195	0.628
32	Thunder Bay	0.345	0.268	0.444
33	Belleville - Quinte West	0.344	0.244	0.486

Table 3: Transit Quality Index scores for 42 Canadian CMAs
(continued)

Rank	CMA	TQI	Supply index	Competitiveness index
34	Trois-Rivières	0.263	0.171	0.404
35	Lethbridge	0.260	0.293	0.232
36	Greater Sudbury / Grand Sudbury	0.259	0.146	0.459
37	Fredericton	0.240	0.122	0.471
38	Saint John	0.197	0.073	0.528
39	Brantford	0.168	0.098	0.290
40	Kamloops	0.162	0.049	0.540
41	Saguenay	0.076	0.000	0.577
42	Chatham-Kent	0.035	0.000	0.125

Note: CMAs ranked by TQI score (descending). All indices scaled 0–1.

The Transit Quality Index relies on modal weights that reflect documented preferences for rail-based transit over bus service. To assess whether the city rankings are sensitive to these choices, the supply index was recomputed under three weight schemes: the chosen weights in the main analysis (bus=1, BRT=1.5, commuter rail=2, LRT=3, subway=5), an equal-weights scheme in which all modes receive a weight of 1, and a flatter alternative scheme (bus=1, BRT=1.2, commuter rail=1.5, LRT=2, subway=3). Rank correlations between the resulting TQI scores are high across all comparisons (Kendall's tau: equal vs. chosen = 0.963, equal vs. alternative = 0.972, chosen vs. alternative = 0.981), indicating that city rankings are stable regardless of the specific modal weight choices.

Table 4: CMA rankings under alternative modal weight schemes

CMA	Equal	Chosen	Alternative	Max rank difference
Vancouver (B)	1	1	1	0
Montréal (B)	2	2	2	0
Toronto (B)	3	3	3	0
Victoria (B)	4	4	5	1
Hamilton (B)	5	5	4	1
Québec (B)	6	6	6	0
Calgary (B)	8	7	7	1
Guelph (B)	7	8	8	1
Oshawa (B)	9	9	9	0
Ottawa - Gatineau (B)	15	10	11	5
Kitchener - Cambridge - Waterloo (B)	12	11	12	1
Kingston (B)	11	12	14	3
Abbotsford - Mission (B)	13	13	13	0

Table 4: CMA rankings under alternative modal weight schemes (*continued*)

CMA	Equal	Chosen	Alternative	Max rank difference
Red Deer (B)	10	14	10	4
Nanaimo (B)	14	15	15	1
Regina (B)	17	16	17	1
Windsor (B)	16	17	16	1
St. Catharines - Niagara (B)	20	18	18	2
Sherbrooke (B)	18	19	19	1
Winnipeg (B)	19	20	20	1
Barrie (B)	23	21	21	2
Edmonton (B)	21	22	22	1
London (B)	22	23	23	1
Halifax (B)	24	24	24	0
Peterborough (B)	25	25	25	0
Drummondville (B)	27	26	27	1
St. John's (B)	26	27	26	1
Chilliwack (B)	28	28	28	0
Moncton (B)	29	29	29	0
Saskatoon (B)	30	30	30	0
Kelowna (B)	31	31	31	0
Thunder Bay (B)	32	32	32	0
Belleville - Quinte West (B)	33	33	33	0
Trois-Rivières (B)	34	34	34	0
Lethbridge (B)	35	35	35	0
Greater Sudbury / Grand Sudbury (B)	36	36	36	0
Fredericton (B)	37	37	37	0
Saint John (B)	38	38	38	0
Brantford (B)	39	39	39	0
Kamloops (B)	40	40	40	0
Saguenay (B)	41	41	41	0
Chatham-Kent (D)	42	42	42	0

8.2 Survey Supplementary Material

Table 5: National means for urban mobility policy attitude items

Item	Mean	N
Transit investment		
My municipality should invest more in transit (even if taxes increase)	0.517	4183
Governments should invest more in transit (even if taxes increase)	0.612	2322
Keep subsidizing transit fares	0.550	1488
Active mobility		
Roads should accommodate active transport (even if sacrificing lanes)	0.572	5001
More bike lanes (even if reducing car lanes)	0.427	1457
Issue salience		
Importance: public transit	0.659	1058
Importance: roads and highways	0.703	1087
Importance: climate change policy	0.559	1029
Investment priorities		
Investment priority: urban vs. suburban	0.459	4200
Investment priority: high vs. low usage	0.425	4189
Investment priority: high vs. low income	0.589	4204

Note: Items coded 0-1. Higher values indicate greater support.

8.3 Modelling Supplementary Material

The intraclass correlation coefficient for the primary outcome is low ($ICC = 0.027$), indicating limited within-city homogeneity in transit attitudes. The comparison of CR2 clustered SE with standard OLS SE for the key predictors in Model 2 confirms that the choice of clustered standard errors does not change the results. Differences between the two approaches are modest and go in both directions, and the conclusions are unchanged regardless of the choice.

Table 6: Comparison of clustered and unclustered standard errors

Term	Coefficient	SE (clustered)	SE (OLS)
Left-right ideology	-0.102	0.038	0.034
Woman	-0.030	0.012	0.015
Public transit	0.103	0.025	0.017
Active transport	0.083	0.021	0.027

Note: CR2 clustered SE by CMA compared to standard OLS SE. $ICC = 0.027$.

Supplementary analyses reveal one exception to the null result on transit quality: Canadians living in cities with better transit quality lean more strongly toward directing investment toward urban rather than suburban areas. This association holds both with and without province fixed effects, though the coefficient attenuates slightly without them (with province FE: $\beta = 0.113$, $\rho = .007$; without province FE: $\beta = 0.089$, $\rho = .012$). This suggests that residents of transit-rich cities, where service is concentrated in urban cores, prefer to maintain that urban orientation rather than expand to suburban areas.

Table 7: TQI coefficient on urban vs. suburban investment allocation

Model	Coefficient	SE	p
With province FE	0.113	0.035	0.007
Without province FE	0.089	0.031	0.012

Note: DV: investment allocation preference (Urban-suburban). Both models include individual-level controls.

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